of Western Francia, the French noble families, landholders and rulers of great estates, paid homage and did as they pleased.[11]

Even at fifteen (or, perhaps, because he *was* fifteen), Philip wanted more power.

He had barely begun his reign when the Duke of Burgundy tried to take advantage of the young king's inexperience by demanding that some of the king's vassals switch allegiance to him instead. Philip II immediately marched into Burgundy, attacked the fortress of Chatillon, and captured the duke's oldest son; he did not release his prisoner until the Duke of Burgundy had backed down. When the Count of Flanders tried to claim territory that belonged, by right of inheritance, to Philip's new wife Isabelle, Philip went to war with him and fought for the next four years over the debated land.[12]

All of this fighting was expensive, and Philip—showing for the first time the ruthlessness towards civilians that would mar his reputation forever—chose a new strategy to raise money. In 1182, he ordered all Jews expelled from France; the king confiscated their lands, seized their synagogues, and wiped out all debt owed to them—as long as the debtors paid one-fifth of the outstanding loan into the royal purse.[13]

The Jews were a natural target. European Christians had long shared the ancient Christian suspicion of Jews as complicit in the crucifixion of Christ, and during the First Crusade this had hardened into open hatred. "We wish to attack the enemies of God in the East, after traveling great distances," wrote the eleventh-century French chronicler Guibert of Nogent. "However, before our eyes are the Jews, and no people is more hostile to God than they are. Such an arrangement is absurd."[14]

Philip was still only in direct control of a small part of Western Francia, so most of the banished Jews did not go far. But the decree uncovered another aspect of the young king's personality. He was harshly inflexible in matters of religion, and his reign was marked by increasingly strict laws against swearing, blasphemy, gambling, and other church-condemned pastimes.

A year after the expulsion decree, Henry the Younger was struck by dysentery and died, aged twenty-seven. His widow Margaret—Philip II's older half sister—had given him only one child, and the baby had died three days after birth.

Seeing another chance to replenish his treasury, Philip II demanded that Henry II of England return Margaret's dowry to the French throne. This, naturally, led to an argument; and by 1186 the quarrel was sliding towards open war.